

SPEAK UP!

A Chinese Parent's Complete Guide to Teaching Kids English at Home

You don't need to be fluent to raise a confident English speaker.

For Children Ages 3-10

WHAT'S INSIDE:

5 Step-by-Step Learning Modules
Age-by-Age Activity Guides (3-5 6-8 9-10)
50 English Phrases with Chinese Translations
Printable Trackers, Planners & Cheat Sheets

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INTRODUCTION

Why This Guide Exists — and Why YOU Can Do This

This guide was written by an ESL teacher for Chinese parents who want to give their children the gift of English — without the confusion, the guilt, or the expensive tutors.

Dear Parent,

If you're holding this guide, you already care deeply about your child's future. English opens doors — to international schools, global careers, and a world of ideas. And you want to be part of that journey.

But you might also be thinking: *My English isn't perfect. I don't know how to teach. What if I do it wrong?*

Here is the truth: You do NOT need to be fluent in English to raise a confident English-speaking child. You just need the right system — and that's exactly what this guide gives you.

What This Guide Will Do For You

- Give you a **clear, simple daily routine** that fits into your busy life
- Show you **age-appropriate activities** for children aged 3 to 10
- Help you **build your child's confidence** — not just their vocabulary
- Give you **50 ready-to-use phrases** (with Chinese translations) so you always know what to say
- Teach you how to track progress **without creating pressure or anxiety**

■ How to Use This Guide

Start with Module 1 to understand the foundations, then jump to the age section in Module 3 that matches your child. You don't need to read everything before starting — pick one activity today and begin.

The Promise of This Guide

By the time you finish reading — and more importantly, by the time you begin doing — your home will feel different. English will stop being a subject and start becoming part of your family's daily life. Your child will start associating English with warmth, play, and connection — not stress or failure. And you will feel like the confident, capable parent you already are.

Let's begin. ■■■! (Let's go!)

MODULE 1

How Kids Actually Learn English

Understanding how children acquire language is the single most important thing you can do before you start teaching. It will save you enormous frustration.

Children Are Not Small Adults

Adults learn languages by studying grammar rules, memorising vocabulary lists, and translating in their heads. Children do not learn this way — and if you try to teach them this way, they will resist, lose interest, and associate English with boredom. Children acquire language through **listening, repetition, play, and meaningful interaction**. They need to hear something many times before they say it, and they need to feel safe before they speak.

The 3 Stages Every Child Goes Through

Stage	Name	What It Looks Like	How Long
1	Silent Period	Child listens and absorbs but doesn't speak much. This is NOT failure.	Weeks to 3 months
2	Repetition	Child repeats words, songs, and phrases. Loves saying the same things.	Months
3	Creation	Child starts forming their own sentences and expressing original ideas.	Ongoing

If your child is silent, they are NOT failing. They are listening. Protect this stage — never force speaking.

5 Common Mistakes Chinese Parents Make

1. Translating everything immediately

When your child hears a word and immediately gets the Chinese translation, their brain stops working to figure out the meaning. Wait. Let them think.

2. Correcting every mistake

Constant correction kills confidence. When your child says 'I goed to school', simply respond naturally: 'Oh, you went to school! What did you do there?'

3. Only using English during 'study time'

Language lives in real life, not textbooks. The bath, the dinner table, the car ride — these are your best classrooms.

4. Expecting too much too soon

A 4-year-old who knows 20 English words is doing brilliantly. Measure progress in months, not weeks.

5. Stopping when the child resists

Some resistance is normal. Keep the routine gentle but consistent. The habit matters more than any single session.

■ The Golden Rule

Make English feel like a GAME, not a lesson. The moment your child thinks they are being tested, the joy disappears. Your job is to make English the fun thing in their day.

MODULE 2

Setting Up Your Home English Environment

You don't need expensive materials or a special room. You need intention — a decision to weave English naturally into your everyday home life.

Create Your 'Mini English World'

Research shows that children learn fastest when language surrounds them naturally. Here are five simple ways to build an English-rich home — most of them free.

◆ Label Your Home

Put sticky labels on 20–30 household objects in English: door, window, table, chair, refrigerator, bed. Your child will absorb these words without any formal teaching.

◆ English Storytime

15 minutes of English picture books before bed. You don't need to read perfectly — point at pictures, say the words, make it playful. The routine matters more than your accent.

◆ English Background Audio

Play English children's songs (Cocomelon, Super Simple Songs) in the background during meals or play. Passive listening builds vocabulary over time.

◆ One English Meal a Week

Choose one meal where everyone tries to use only English. Keep it light and fun — laugh at mistakes together. This one habit alone is transformative.

◆ English Corner

Dedicate one small shelf or corner with English books, flashcards, and a few toys. When your child goes there, English begins.

Sample Daily Routines by Age

AGES 3–5 (10 MINUTES PER DAY)

- Morning • Sing one English song together (2 min)
- Daytime • Name 5 objects around the house in English (3 min)
- Evening • Read one English picture book at bedtime (5 min)

AGES 6–8 (15 MINUTES PER DAY)

- Morning • English greeting routine: 'Good morning! How are you?' (2 min)
- After school • Flashcard game or English app (8 min)
- Evening • English read-aloud + 2 questions about the story (5 min)

AGES 9–10 (20 MINUTES PER DAY)

- Morning • English journal: write 3 sentences about yesterday (5 min)

→ Afternoon • Watch a short English video + discuss (10 min)

→ Evening • English conversation practice over dinner (5 min)

■ **Consistency**
Beats Intensity

10 minutes every day is worth more than 2 hours on the weekend. Build a small, sustainable habit. After 30 days it will feel automatic.

MODULE 3

Age-by-Age Activity Guides

Every age needs a different approach. Find your child's age group and follow the activities — they are all designed to be fun, fast, and doable at home with no special materials.

AGES 3–5: LISTEN & PLAY

At this age, your child's brain is a sponge. They learn through songs, movement, repetition, and play. Do not worry about reading or writing — focus entirely on listening and speaking.

Best Activities

◆ Body Parts Song

Sing 'Head, Shoulders, Knees and Toes' while touching each body part. Repeat until your child can do it alone.

◆ Colour Hunt

Call out a colour in English and your child runs to touch something that colour. 'Find something RED! Find something BLUE!'

◆ Animal Sounds Game

Show flashcards of animals. Child must make the sound AND say the animal name. 'What's this?' — 'COW! Mooooo!'

◆ Bedtime Word of the Day

Each night at bedtime, introduce one new English word. Say it 3 times together. By the end of the week, that's 7 new words.

◆ Simple Simon Says

Classic game, full English instructions. 'Simon says touch your nose! Simon says jump three times!' Children love this.

■ Key Milestone for Ages 3–5

By age 5, your child should recognise and respond to 50–100 common English words (colours, numbers 1–10, body parts, animals, family members). If they're there — celebrate! If not — keep playing, no pressure.

AGES 6–8: READ & SPEAK

This is the golden age for reading foundations. Children at this stage can begin connecting sounds to letters and forming simple sentences. Make this exciting — reading is a superpower.

Best Activities

◆ Sight Word Bingo

Create simple bingo cards with common sight words (the, I, and, is, go, see, like, can, we, my). Call out words, child covers them. First to get a row wins!

◆ Story Retelling

After reading a picture book, ask: 'What happened first? What happened next? How did the story end?' Simple 3-part structure builds speaking confidence.

◆ English at the Dinner Table

Each family member says one thing in English about their day. Keep it simple: 'Today I ate noodles. I played with my friend. I read a book.'

◆ Word Family Charts

Teach word families together: cat/bat/rat/hat, big/pig/wig/dig. Rhyming patterns make reading faster and more fun.

◆ Role-Play Scenarios

Act out real situations in English: going to a restaurant, buying something at a shop, meeting a new friend. Kids love drama.

■ Key Milestone for Ages 6–8

By age 8, your child should be able to read simple sentences independently, write a few sentences with help, and hold a basic 3–5 exchange conversation in English on a familiar topic.

AGES 9–10: THINK & EXPRESS

At this age, children can handle more complex language and begin developing their own voice in English. The goal shifts from 'saying words' to 'expressing ideas'. Encourage creativity and independent thinking.

Best Activities

◆ English Journaling

3 sentences every day. Prompts: 'The best thing about today was... If I could change one thing... I am grateful for...' Don't correct grammar — focus on the habit of writing.

◆ YouTube English Challenge

Watch a 3-minute English video (nature, cooking, travel). Then ask: What was it about? What was one interesting fact? What word did you not understand?

◆ Opinion Debates

Give your child a fun topic: 'Is a dog or a cat a better pet?' They must argue their side in English for 2 minutes. Judge based on effort, not perfect grammar.

◆ English Book Club

Read the same English book together (graded readers work well). Discuss one chapter at a time. Let your child lead the discussion.

◆ Teach Me Something

Your child teaches YOU something in English. Anything — a game, how to draw something, a fact they learned at school. Teaching reinforces language powerfully.

At every age, the most important thing you can give your child is your TIME and your ENTHUSIASM. Your energy is contagious — if you make English fun, they will love it.

MODULE 4

Handling the Hard Moments

Every parent hits roadblocks. This module gives you honest, practical answers to the most common challenges Chinese parents face when teaching English at home.

"My child refuses to speak English."

This is extremely common. Never force speaking. Instead, remove the pressure completely — go back to pure listening activities (songs, videos, audiobooks) for 1–2 weeks. When a child feels zero pressure to perform, they naturally start speaking. Also check: are you accidentally making English feel like a test? The fix is almost always more play, less evaluation.

"My child mixes Chinese and English — is that bad?"

No — this is called code-switching and it is completely normal and even cognitively healthy. Bilingual children mix languages as they build their systems. Do not punish or correct it. Simply model the full English version in your response and move on naturally.

"I feel embarrassed because my English isn't perfect."

Your child does not need a perfect model — they need an enthusiastic one. Studies consistently show that children learn more from engaged parents with imperfect English than from perfect strangers they don't connect with. Your love and effort matter infinitely more than your accent.

"We started well but now we've stopped. How do I restart?"

Don't restart big — restart tiny. One song. One label. One English word at dinner. Consistency is built from tiny moments, not heroic efforts. Forgive yourself for the gap and take one small step today.

"My child's school English is very different from what we do at home."

This is fine. School English focuses on grammar and exams. Home English focuses on confidence and communication. Both serve your child. Don't try to align them perfectly — they are complementary, not competing.

■ For YOU, the Parent

Teaching a language to your own child can feel emotional. You may feel anxious, impatient, or guilty. This is normal. Take a breath. You are doing something beautiful for your child's future. Progress is always happening, even when you cannot see it.

MODULE 5

Tracking Progress Without Pressure

Progress in language learning is slow, invisible, then suddenly obvious. Here's how to measure it in a way that motivates rather than discourages.

Milestones by Age

Age	Listening	Speaking	Reading/Writing
3–4	Responds to simple commands	Understands 30 words; animal sounds	Recognises own name
4–5	Follows 2-step instructions	Simple phrases (I want, I see)	Recognises letters A–Z
5–6	Understands simple stories	Short sentences (I like dogs)	Reads 20–50 sight words
6–7	Understands most classroom English	Engage in simple conversations	Reads simple sentences
7–8	Follows TV shows with simple English	Describe pictures & events	Reads short paragraphs
9–10	Understands complex stories	Expresses opinions & reasons	Reads chapter books

Monthly Check-In: 5 Questions to Ask Yourself

1. Does my child ENJOY our English time? (If no — change the activity, not the routine)
2. Have I heard at least one new English word or phrase from my child this month?
3. Is our daily routine still happening? (Even 3–4 days/week counts as success)
4. Has my child shown any interest in English outside our sessions? (TV, asking questions)
5. Do I feel good about our English journey together? (Your energy is the engine)

If you answer YES to 3 or more questions: You are doing brilliantly. Keep going. If you answer YES to 1–2: Adjust one thing — make it easier, shorter, or more playful. If you answered YES to 0: Take this week off. Then restart with just 5 minutes.

When to Consider Adding a Tutor

Home English learning is powerful — but a tutor or class can be a great addition (not a replacement) when: your child has mastered the basics and needs more challenge; your child needs peer interaction in English; or you want to prepare for an English-medium school. Look for tutors who use communicative methods — not those who rely mainly on grammar drills and translation. Your child should leave every session smiling.

Print these pages and stick them on your fridge, your child's bedroom door, or anywhere you'll see them every day.

You don't need to be fluent. These 50 phrases cover the most common daily moments — greetings, mealtimes, praise, bedtime, and learning. Use just 3–5 of them consistently and your child will absorb them naturally.

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■ What does this word mean?

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Let's read together.

■■■■■■■■

■ Point to the picture.

■■■■■■

■ Repeat after me.

■■■■■■

■ Good try! Keep going!

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Do you understand?

■■■■■■■■

PRAISE & ENCOURAGEMENT

■ I'm so proud of you!

■■■■■■■■■■■■

■ You're getting better every day!

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Keep trying — you're doing great!

■■■■ ——— ■■■■■■

■ That was amazing!

■■■■■■■■

■ High five! You did it!

■■■■■■■■■■

PLAYTIME

■ Let's play a game!

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Your turn! / My turn!

■■■■■/■■■■■

■ What do you want to play?

■■■■■■■■

■ Be careful!

■■■

■ Clean up time! Put your toys away.

■■■■■■■■■■■■■■

BEDTIME

■ Time for bed!

■■■■■■

■ Let's brush your teeth.

■■■■■■■■

■ Shall we read a story?

■■■■■■■■■■■■

■ Close your eyes. Sleep tight.

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Sweet dreams! I love you.

■■■■■■■■■■

EMOTIONS & EVERYDAY

■ Are you okay?

■■■■■

■ I understand. It's okay.

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Take a deep breath.

■■■■■

■ Tell me what happened.

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Don't worry. I'm here.

■■■■■■■■■■

■ You make me so happy!

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Let's do this together.

■■■■■■■■■■

■ Please / Thank you / You're welcome.

■ / ■■■ / ■■■■■

■ Excuse me / I'm sorry.

■■■■■ / ■■■■■

■ What a great question!

■■■■■■■■■■

Top Free Resources for Chinese Families

Category	Resource	Best For
YouTube	Super Simple Songs	Ages 2–6: songs & nursery rhymes
YouTube	Cocomelon	Ages 2–6: stories & daily life English
YouTube	Dave and Ava	Ages 3–7: phonics & alphabet
YouTube	English Singsing	Ages 4–8: vocabulary & sentences
App	Duolingo ABC	Ages 3–7: reading fundamentals (free)
App	Khan Academy Kids	Ages 2–8: full English curriculum (free)
App	Starfall	Ages 5–8: phonics & early reading
Books	Oxford Reading Tree	Ages 4–8: graded readers, widely available
Books	Dr. Seuss series	Ages 3–8: rhyme, rhythm & fun vocabulary
Books	Magic Tree House	Ages 7–10: chapter books, adventure stories

You have everything you need. You have this guide. You have the love. You have the commitment. Start small. Stay consistent. Celebrate every tiny win. Your child's English journey begins at home — and it begins with you. ■■■(You've got this!)

Thank you for investing in your child's future. Share this guide with another parent who needs it.

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